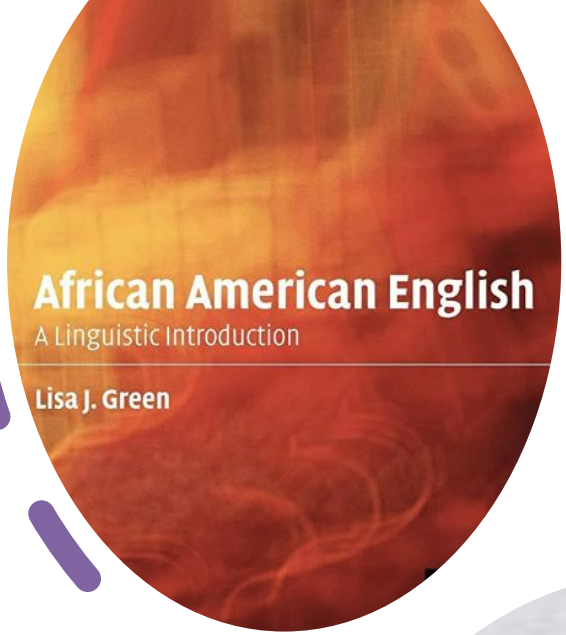
(Accents and) Dialects in the US

UMass Amherst LING 101

People and Their Language

AAVE at UMass Amherst

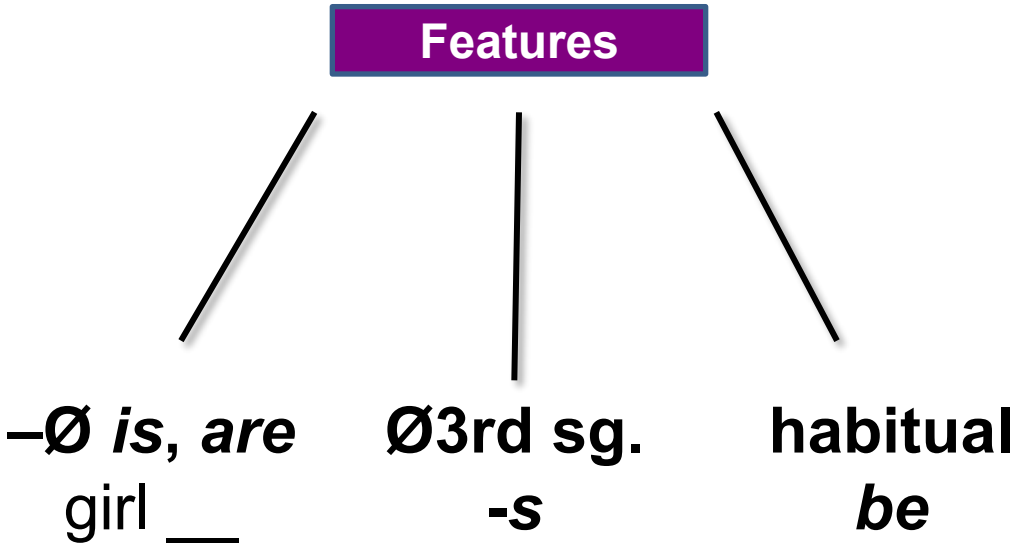
- UMass Amherst has a center for the study of African American Language
- The director is Prof. Lisa Green
- She's the author of multiple books, articles



AAVE is a distinct dialect

- Spoken by some African American
- Words: kitchen (neck hair), get over (taken advantage of)
- Accent: r-dropping
- Grammar: our focus today

Characterizing AAE: Features



1. **The student __ reading. / That book __ too expensive.**
2. **He drive too fast.**
3. **The student be reading those sentences too fast.**

In mainstream English: 'The student reads those sentences too fast'

Definition of AAE

Systems & Patterns

Inherently variable linguistic variety that has set syntactic, phonological, semantic, pragmatic, and lexical patterns that are intertwined with structures of general English

Idealized General English — **Idealized African American English**

A **B** **C** **D**

Negotiating between different and ungrammatical

Dialect A

She be reading too fast.

He was steady reading.

Dialect B

She usually reads too fast.

He was reading intensely and consistently.

Shifting continuum

Shifting within AAE **Shifting to GAE**

AAE

She reading.	She**'s** reading.	
She read.	She reads.	
They **be** walking fast.	They usually walk fast.	
You wanna leave?	**Do** you wanna leave?	
his sister book		his sister**'s** book

What’s aspect?

- Aspect is a property of verbs, like tense
- Aspect relates the action of the verb to the passage of time
- Tense is different: when the action occurs

Standard English has two aspects

- Completed (perfective)

(1) Jane has written her assignments (she’s done)

- On-going (progressive)

(2) Jane is writing her assignments (she still has more to do)

Aspect in AAVE

- AAVE has a much more complex aspect system
- We'll look at four basic AAVE aspects, plus two combinations

Habitual aspect

- Marked by be. Means *usually*
- *I be in my office by 7:30*
- *It be knives in there. It be ice-picks in there*
- *She be telling people she eight*
- *Your phone bill be high, don't it?*
- *It don't be drove hardly*

Perfective aspect

- Marked by done. Meaning *finished*
- *John done his assignments*
- *I told him you done changed*
- *I done already finished that*
- *People would say that medicine I'm taking done make me sick*

Momentaneous aspect

- Marked by verb+ing (“is” is optional), meaning *right now*
- John (is) writing his assignments

Remote aspect

- Marked by stressed been [BIN]
- Meaning *for a long time*
- *I BIN knowing he died*
- *The police going bad / they ain't going bad. They BIN bad.*
- *Where'd you get that shirt? / I BIN had it*

Habitual + Perfective

- Meaning usually finished

- John *be done wrote* his assignments

Perfective + remote

- Meaning *finished a long time ago*

- John *been done wrote* his assignments